

The Sky Net

1

Wind come crossways, dust-sharp, skatin low over the rib-walk so it hiss under my boots.

I set my feet wide on the slatted grating, both hands on the guide-rail till the bone-hum in the metal line up with my own chest beat. Long drop under me, all the way past the shanty-clutch clingin to the tower ribs, past the pipe forest, down into that brown smear where ground an vent haze melt together. High Spire Twenny-3 breathe slow round me: old steel creak, heat-sigh pullin up from the Deep Reg vents, rope squeak somewheres downshaft.

Same bone, same breath, same as always. Whole life hung off this rib.

"Crew!" I call, voice snatched thin an flung out along the walk. "Where my ribs-hand at? Jall, Tann—any of you dead, best shout now so I don waste my count."

Shadows peel off the shanties, out from patchwork door-sheets an gap-walls. First Tann, big-shoulder rope-thick, beard gone mostly rust-grey. Harness already cinched proper, hooks an carabs kissin metal in that neat ring-click I love more nor prayers. Then skinny Pera, half-awake, rubbin one eye with the back of her hand. Chos and Len behind, still arguin low 'bout shares like the tower gon listen.

Last, Jall come half-run, half-trip along the grating, green scarf flappin loose round his neck, harness straps hangin like they try run away from him.

"I here, Riya!" he puff. "Ent late, I jus—"

"You late," I say. "Sun up, wind right, tower beat clean, an you still draggin. Sky gon wait on you? Bone gon say, oh, Jall need more sleep, we hold the whole spire? Ent."

He skid to a stop in front me, near knock Len sideways. Try stand tall, chest heaving, eyes big.

"How many marked on the board?" I ask, already countin faces.

"Twelve sign," Tann rumbles. "Got six show."

I spit over the rail, watch it vanish. "Other six off-sick, yeah? Catch a bad case of 'Kerrun skim too heavy this week'?"

Pera snort. "Bashta say he got cough."

"Bashta always got cough when the plate run deep." I shake my head. "Fine. Six we got, six we take. Six we bring back."

I pace down the line, tappin each harness ring with my knuckles, makin 'em sound off.

"Name it."

"Tann," Tann says, solid as bone.

"Pera."

"Chos."

"Len."

"Jall," the boy squeak.

Six heads. Six chest, six rope, six skull I'm responsible for.

"Six head," I say. "Hear me now. High Spire take six head down today, it don get to keep any. Six head go, six head come. That the ribs-law."

"Six head go, six head come," they mutter back, some strong, some just breath.

"Say it right," I snap.

They straighten a little, voices comin together. "Six head go, six head come."

"Mm." I jerk my chin at their belts. "Hands up, straps out. We do harness clean fore I even think 'fall-way.'"

Harness check the only part I trust; hands and eyes, not luck and tower mood.

"Lift," I tell Tann.

He raise his arms. I tug each strap, thumb the webbin where it fold back through the buckle. Double-backed proper, no daylight.

"Still tie like a real ribs-hand," I say.

"Muscle got memory," Tann grunts. "Wish the rest of me forget this work."

"You die, we feed you to the vents," I tell him. "Save you the trouble complainin."

He huff something like a laugh.

Pera next. I frown at a long tail of webbin hangin loose.

"You tryin make snack-meat for the fall-way?" I flick the strap; it swings. "Fold that under. Ent show no daylight in a harness on my crew."

She flush dark under the dust, fingers fumblin. "Got it, Riya. Was gon fix—"

"You fix when I say fix," I cut in, but I tap her shoulder quick with my knuckles. "You want Net Up look down see you all sloppy? Ma Tron make three sermons off that."

At Jall I stop dead.

The boy done wrapped his chest strap 'round once an tied it off in a big fat lump like he bundlin rope for storage. Big sorry knot, sittin proud and stupid against his ribs.

I just stare a moment. Then I hook a finger under the lump an give it one light pull. Whole mess sag loose at once.

"This a what?" I ask.

"A... knot?" he tries.

"This a sorry," I say. "This ent no knot. You fall on that, harness gon smile, give you a little kiss, an let you go. Tower take you in one bite, spit you out the vent in little Jall bits. That what you want?"

His ears go red above the scarf. "No, Riya. I was gon—"

"No you ent." I grab his wrist and the loose webbin both. "Look. Through, back, pull. Hear that bite?"

I feed the strap through the buckle slow, double it back on itself, yank till the fibers sing. Give it another savage tug. Harness bite back, solid.

"That the feel," I say. "Say it."

"That a knot," he mutter.

"Louder."

"That a knot."

"Good." I slap the buckle. "Next time you tie a sorry, it ent your hands I hit."

I move on, speedin up now—Len's gear okay, Chos got one twisted leg strap I fix with a sharp twist an a curse. Then I step back, look at the line of 'em: six bodies in patched harness, boots scuffed near through, dust scarves ready to pull up over their mouths.

"Right," I say. "We walkin past dead glass on the way down. You all know the talk. What folk say?"

"Don look a black screen dead-on," Pera recite. "Don call Sky Mind by name near dead glass."

"Mm." My mouth twitch. "Folk say that, true. Folk also say if you whistle in the fall-way, Net Up hear you an drop the lift. Folk say a lot of mess."

"You don believe?" Jall ask, curious an scared both.

I lean in close so he can smell metal-sweat on me. "I believe tower bone crack when folk do stupid," I say. "I believe bad welds an tired plate kill more crew nor any ghost ever did. But—" I straighten "—you wanna spit at myth, you do it where Ma Tron ent listenin. I got no taste for chapel talk lashed on my back."

We set off along the rib-walk toward the big square mouth where fall-way cut into the spire. Grating rattle underfoot, tower wind push at our sides. Far below, I hear kids laughin faint in the shanties, an somewhere the hollow clang of some fool try fix a stove by kickin it.

We pass under one of the old panels: slab of dead glass, spiderwebbed, bolted crooked into a frame high over the walk. Somebody long time back painted an eye on it—white circle, black pupil run out with weather, little lash-lines flared—and hung twisted copper scraps on string from the corners so they tink and spin in the wind.

Pera touch her fingers to the frame twice as she go under, quick. "Net Up don look, Net Up don drop," she whisper.

Len do same. Chos mutter along.

I roll my eyes. "You lot know that thing ent seen nothin in a hundred year," I say.

Still, when I duck under, my knuckles rap the metal once, light. Just a little tap. Habit sit deeper nor sense.

"Net Up got better places to stare," I mutter, mostly to myself. "If it even still got eyes."

Beyond the panel, the walk broaden for a stretch where three ribs meet. Half the settlement live hung off those joints: tin walls, tarp roofs, a whole tangle of scrap ladders an rope bridges stitched together. Smell of cook smoke an old oil, piss driftin up from the buckets strapped under platform edges.

Off left, tucked into a bay under patched awnin, Kerrun's weigh-station squat like a tick.

My jaw tighten as soon as I see the red-mark boards, the neat stacks of scrap one side and the lighter stacks the other. The man himself ent at the rail yet, but his sigil—two crossed hooks over a split plate—painted big on the wall, fresh-bright.

His boys there, though. Two of 'em loungin in the shade, harness clean, boots without a hole, each with a tally-board in hand. They watch me an my crew go by with slow eyes, countin future metal.

Tall one with the split lip raise two fingers in lazy salute. "Fall-way open?" he call. "You ribs lot gon bring us somethin nice, yeah?"

"We bring what bone give," I say, don't stop. "Same as always."

"Make sure it come through proper." He tap his board. "Kerrun say he got right of first weigh on all plate off Twenny-3 this week."

"Funny," I say, low, for my crew not him. "I don remember signin no such."

Last thing I need is quarrel here with my ropes not even clipped. So I file it away instead, another weight in the back of my skull: Kerrun watchin the fall-way like a hungry vent. Shares gon run thinner if I let him.

Past the station, ribs narrow again, walls closin in to raw tower metal. Someone hung Ma Tron's banners here too, strips of cloth painted with old circuit lines and sunburst eyes, flappin limp in the wind. Sky Mind see you, Sky Mind judge you, all that.

I duck under one without lookin up.

Fall-way mouth gape ahead, tall square hacked into tower side. Metal teeth of track rails run down into dark, vanish. Old lift-cage hang just inside, mesh sides patched and repatched, main descent line coiled like a sleepin snake through the pulley crown.

Air here got different taste: cooler, laced with vent-breath comin straight up from deep. Tower heart beat clear through the rail under my palm—steady, familiar thrum.

"Right," I say, turn back to my crew. "Listen close now. What the ribs-law?"

"Two hand, one tower," they chorus, almost together. "Line first, step sure, no dance on the edge."

"Again," I say.

They say it again, louder. Even Jall.

"You keep one hand for you, one hand for bone," I tell 'em. "You don unclip 'less I say unclip. You don lean out 'less I say lean. You feel plate shift under you, you yell. You feel rope sing wrong, you yell louder. You get clever on my line, I kick you off myself, save the tower the trouble. Clear?"

"Clear," Tann say; others echo.

I move down the line one last time, checkin buckles with quick hard tugs, touchin each shoulder in turn. Tann, Pera, Chos, Len, Jall. Six heads.

Lead hook sit on its rest, a little grit on the metal. I take it, clip myself into the main descent line with a solid click that echoes up into the throat of the fall-way.

Sound like the start of a prayer. Or the start of a drop.

"Clip in," I say.

One by one, they step up and snap their harness rings to the line. Staggered run of little metal heartbeats, each one a promise the tower might or might not keep.

"Feel it bite," I say. "Don just listen for click. Pull it. Make it talk back."

Tann yanks his line like he draggin a stubborn mule. Pera does it gentler, but I hear the hitch in the rope when the carab settle. Jall give his a timid tug till I raise a brow at him; then he hauls proper, face screwed up, like he expect the whole tower to fall on him.

"Why they call it fall-way, anyway?" he ask, tryin to sound casual. "Could call it lift-hole or downshaft or some such."

"'Cause first folk what used it fell," I say. "Before your Da's Da time, they say Com'welth had big shiny cages that run up and down by themselves. Door shut, you don even see the drop. One day the holds go bug, or the Sky Mind

blink wrong, or some fool skip the checks." I jerk my chin at the dark throat of the shaft. "Cage drop three ribs in a breath. Killed a whole crew so fast bone dint even get a scream out."

Jall swallow. His rope creak.

"Could be ghost still fallin," Chos mutter, doin her best Ma Tron voice. "Them what trust in cold machine get taken quick into the Deep Reg fire."

Pera snicker. Tann spit.

"Ma Tron can kiss my left boot," Tann say. "She never hang off no line in her life."

"She hang off Sky Lip plenty," Pera shoot back. "You seen her sermons. Whole body lean out, arms up like she gna grab Net Up by the neck."

"Enough," I cut in. "Story time over. We work now."

I step to the anchor point: big cross-beam sunk deep into tower ribs, old Com'welth metal with newer patch welds flashin dull under the dust. Our main hook lives there when we ent usin it, fat chunk of steel wedged into a ring-weld. I check it first—weld seams, no new cracks; touch the metal where rust ate shallow; give it a test shake.

It answers with that same low, stubborn hum I know. "Still here, old bone," I murmur. "Good."

Above us, we got the winch they scrounged off a dead cargo dock a decade back. Half the casing gone, guts all bare spool and grease. When it turns it make this ugly grind-squeal that send kids runnin the first time they hear it.

"Jall," I say. "Eyes."

He snaps to attention. "Eyes on anchor," he chant. "Eyes on knots. Eyes on brake."

"Mm. You see that brake slip, you yell 'til tower itself flinch, yeah?"

"Yes, Riya."

I lean into the winch, crank it once to feel the give. Teeth catch slow but sure. Little hop in the handle where it pass the busted bit, then it settle into that familiar pull.

"Still bite," I say. "Sound bad, hold good. Same as Tann."

"Oi," Tann grunt, but he grinning.

They laugh a little, nerves loosening. That what I want—fear low enough they can move, high enough they don do stupid.

"No hand spare for scratchin your arse once we over," I tell 'em. "You got itch, you scratch it with your eyes. You think 'bout every grip, every step. That how we come back with all our bits."

"Ribs-law," Pera say under her breath.

"Ribs-law," I echo.

I clip my safety short into the side ring, then step right up to the lip. The shaft breathes cool up my face, smells of old dust and Deep Reg heat. Down there somewhere, the vents cough fire into the guts of the world so the towers can drink.

"Riya go first," Len says, like she sayin sunrise come east.

"Course I go first," I snort. "I don't fancy watchin you lot try an draw me pictures of how the plate look."

I turn my back to the hole, heels just at the edge. Hands on the line above my head, feelin the tension. For a heartbeat I just stand there, lookin at my crew all lined up, their eyes big in the dim. Wind from the shaft flick Jall's scarf, rattle Pera's ear bits.

"This the part where we pretend we all got wings," I say. "Only wings we got is rope an weld. You trust them, they trust you."

Then I step back into the emptiness.

For a blink my stomach come up in my throat, like always. Then the line catch full, harness bite into my hips and chest, boots plant against the shaft wall. Old concrete rough under my soles, little bits flakin. Body angled, knees bent.

"There," I call up. My voice bounce round in the throat. "See? No fall, no ghost, just bone and rope."

I walk my feet down a little, lettin out line hand over hand. Wall here pocked, paint long gone, Com'welth hazard stripes ghost-faded under grime. I find a solid patch, dig my toes in.

"Next," I call.

Tann come over the lip steady as if he steppin off a low stoop. He's done this so many times his body know the dance without him. Harness creak, rope sing, boots land solid. He grin round his beard like he enjoy the drop.

"Still ain't tired of this?" I ask.

"Got worse ways to earn a share," he say. "Least this one honest. Tower try kill you to your face."

Pera next. She hesitates just a fraction at the lip, lookin down past us into the dark. I catch her rope in my gloved hand, give it a reassuring jerk.

"Look at me," I say. "Not the hole."

She drag her gaze back up. I can see the swallow in her throat.

"Feet on wall, Pera," I tell her. "Think of it as ground come up to you. It ent magic. Just angle."

She breathes out, steps back, and then she's there beside us, boots skidding a little till she finds her stance.

"Good," I say. "You don't shake too much, I guess you're made of stone, have to throw you off myself."

"Ent stone," she mutters. "Just don't wanna be paste neither."

Chos and Len come over after, each with their own flavor of pretend-brave. Len hums some half-song through clenched teeth, Chos keeps up a low stream of curses like that glue her to the wall.

Jall's last, of course.

He edges up to the margin, looks down, looks at us, looks down again. I can see his hands sweat where they grip the line.

"You got two choices," I tell him. "You step over. Or I come up there and push you over. Either way you're coming."

"That's not a proper choice," he whispers.

"World's not proper," I say. "We work with what we got."

He shuts his eyes, mutters something that sounds like half of Ma Tron's prayer and half of a swear, then steps back. For a heart-skip he flails, boots scraping, and my stomach jumps, but then his harness catches and he slams into the wall with a grunt.

"Keep your knees soft," I bark. "You lock 'em, you bounce. You bounce, you bruise."

He obeys quickly, legs bending, boots settling.

"Good." I reach out with my free hand and thump his shoulder. "See? Fall-way, not fall-down."

He laughs once, breathless and shaky. "Hate it," he says.

"You s'posed to," I answer. "If you ever love this, you're sick in the head."

We start down properly.

Our little chain of bodies walks the wall, ropes feeding through hands and winch. Above, the mechanism chunk-chunk-grinds like some old animal with bad teeth. The shaft swallows us, the world outside shrinks to a thin square of light up top.

We pass a cross-ladder someone bolted in long ago, now hanging useless, rungs twisted. Old cabling dangles in loops big as my torso, some of it dead, some of it still humming faint where it vanishes into tower guts. I keep us clear; the last thing I need is somebody snagging a rope on a live line.

"Watch your right," I call. "Big rust patch, don't scrape your suit on it, you don't want Deep Reg itch on your legs."

"Left foot high," a breath later. "There's a crack there. You step in it, you twist."

They follow, echoes of my words comin back jumbled: "Right, rust, left foot, crack." Little human chorus in the bone-throat.

We slide past a set of faded Com'welth glyphs painted vertical along the wall—block letters nobody up here can read clean anymore. Yellow triangles, red stripin. Once it all shouted hazard, capacity, maintenance schedules. Now it just ghost paint.

Jall squint at them as we go by. "What that say?"

"Say 'don be stupid,'" I answer. "Same as all the rest."

"You don know," he push.

"I know enough." I bump his rope a little. "Eyes on your feet, reader-boy. Books ain't gon catch you."

The further down we go, the cooler the air turn, thin sweat on my back chillin. I breathe in deep. Like drinkin from a different world.

"Listen," I say, and we all go quiet.

For a moment, all I hear is the scrape of our boots, the little squeals of metal, the grunt of the winch. Beneath that, deeper, the tower's own song: slow thrum of vent pumps, low rumble where heat trade hands between stone and pipe.

"That the rhythm you marry," I tell Jall, who always ask the most questions. "Bone beat steady, you fine. Bone beat change, you get loud quick."

"How I know if it change?" he ask.

"You gon know," I say. "Same way you know when your own heart skip. Body tell you, even if head slow."

He go quiet at that, listenin hard. Good. Maybe I got through for once.

We pass another level where the shaft open out onto a side ledge choked with scrap and old lift parts. Somebody long time back spray-painted a crude arrow there, pointin up, then crossed it out and painted a bigger arrow pointin down.

Tann chuckle. "Folk love think down the only way now."

"Up cost more," Pera say. "Kerrun tax air if he could."

"Kerrun gon tax your tongue if you keep sayin his name in my shaft," I snap. "Save that talk for after. We near plate."

I can feel it in the change of the wall: concrete givin way to bolted-on sections, seams closer, little weep lines where old heat plates once leaked. The tower's breath come hotter here, a gustin exhale through cracks we can't see.

"Few more step," I call. "Then we swing in. You keep your knees soft, your grip hard, and you don't show the ledge your teeth, y'hear? It already got enough bones."

Light shifts below, a wider grey patch where the shaft opens to our work ledge.

Bone beat steady. Ropes hold. Just another day in the fall-way.

Ledge come up fast.

One breath we just shadows on the shaft wall, next breath my boots hit metal and it dip under me like a thin tongue. I bend my knees, ride it, testin the give.

"Hold," I mutter to the bone.

It flex, but it don't let go. I feel the support braces underneath, that old Com'welth cross-frame still carryin more than it got right to.

"Ledge take," I call up. "Come gentle, you lot. Ent no spare ribs if this one drop."

One by one they swing in. Tann first, like always, body heavy but sure. He land with a grunt, boots skidin half a handspan till he catch the wall.

"Still here," he say.

"World's shame," I tell him.

He grin round his beard.

Pera next, then Chos and Len. Jall last, rope squeal a little as he swing wide, then bang into the wall and scrabble till he find his feet.

"Whole Spire hear that," I say. "Try not bash no holes in it we ent paid for."

He pant-laugh, shakier than he mean to show. "Sorry, Riya."

We stand packed tight for a moment, six bodies on a strip ledge just three boot-width out from the shaft. On the shaft side, a waist-high lip of bent metal keep you from walkin straight off; on the tower side, the wall rise up near vertical, choked with dead conduits, old bracket arms, and three big heat plates sittin overlapped like rotten scales.

I stomp my heel twice, feel the answer all the way up my spine.

"Plate ledge hold," I say. "For today, anyway."

"Tha what I like," Tann mutter. "A nice soft promise."

"Right." I tap my carab. "Clip short on wall, then we get to it. Jall, you take rope tail. You don let no slack run wild, y'hear? Rope go spook-wigglin, that mean somebody slippin."

He nods too fast. "Got it. Rope don wiggle 'less I say."

"Good boy. Tann, you on big bolt. You touch nothing till I say which. Pera, Chos, Len, you all on side arms an small fixin. We strip what we can safe, leave the rest for them what love fallin."

I move down the ledge, hip brushin the wall, runnin my glove over the nearest plate. It near as tall as I am, thick old composite set over ribs of metal. Blackened, bubbled in spots where the tower cooked itself back before they learned better.

I rap it with my knuckles. Sound come back dull and thick, a kind of choked ring.

"This the one," I say. "Hear that? Plate full of tired heat. Keeps tower from cookin its own ribs. When it go bad, all that heat go where it ent suppose."

"Up to us, then," Tann say, heftin his wrench. Thing big as my arm, head chewed from too many bolt heads.

"As ever," I shrug. "We keep the old bone from eatin itself, it maybe let us hang on one more season. You don, we all find out how the Deep Reg taste without no lift."

They get to it.

Tann plant himself by the top bracket, loop his safety line shorter, brace both boots and set wrench teeth on a corroded bolt big as a child's wrist.

"Ready on rope," Jall call, like I taught him.

"Ready," I say.

"Then we twist this bastard," Tann grunt.

He haul. Metal scream, this long dry eeeeeee like somethin dyin slow. Rust dust come down in a little orange fog. The bolt don move first go. Tann reset, face go red, beard bristle.

"C'mon, old Cold Com," he mutter. "Let loose your teeth."

Second pull, the bolt jumps. The whole plate gives a little twitch against the wall.

"Easy," I warn. "Top first, then sides. We keep that weight sittin till we know where it wanna fall."

"Pera," I nod down. "You on lower arm. Take them little clamp bolts one at a time, yeah? Don strip 'em."

She already got her little socket stick out, eyes narrowed. "I know, Riya."

Chos and Len start workin the cable harness that once fed flow data back Up. Half them lines dead, cut; other half still vanish into tower guts. They talk low as they work, normal rib nonsense.

"Bet Kerrun skim half this plate fore it even hit the scales," Chos say, slicin a strap.

"Kerrun skim his own Ma if he could weigh her," Len snort.

"Less talk 'bout Kerrun, more talk 'bout where your hands at," I cut in. "You get your fingers where my plate gon fall, you ent got fingers no more."

They hush. Wrench turns, bolts squeal, little showers of bright sparks pop when Len's cutter kiss an old bracket. Smell of hot metal, old dust, a faint tang of burnt oil rise up. Shaft wind suck it all toward the bright square above, thin grey streamers of smoke twistin in the draft.

For a few minutes, it all feel right. Work-sure. This the beat I live in: grunt, clank, scrape, my crew talkin nonsense 'tween orders. Tower hum in the wall, slow steady under my hand.

I plant my palm flat on the plate, feel the vibrations travel through. Bone song. Same as always.

"Jall, how your rope?" I ask without lookin.

"Rope fine," he say. "Little bit of jiggle from Tann, but she hold."

"She?" Pera echo. "You givin the rope a name now?"

"Rope always a she," Tann grunt. "Else she drop you just to prove a point."

They laugh. Even I smile.

"Look at us," I say. "All you lot makin jokes. Must be we forget we hangin over a big hungry nothin."

"Jus means you trained us good," Pera shoot back. "Fear on the inside now."

I about to answer when the wall change.

It subtle first. Bone hum skip half a breath, like the tower take a cough. My hand still on the plate; I feel it there before my ears catch it. That steady low thrum twist, all stretched wrong for a heartbeat.

"Hold," I start to say—

Then the shudder hits.

It ent the usual sway from wind or vent burp. This a sharp, off-tempo jerk that run sideways through the wall, throwin our bodies the wrong way. The plate buck under my palm, yanked out at the bottom as if somethin kick from inside.

Tann's half-loosened top bolt scream, metal against metal. Jall's rope give a high, panicked sing as it take sudden load. Pera's wrench jump from her hand, bounce off the plate, go whirlin toward the shaft lip.

"ROPE!" I bellow. "FEET WIDE! THREE POINTS TOUCH!"

The ledge tilt just enough my stomach try climb out my mouth. Chos' boots skid; she swing out on her harness, one foot scrabblin.

I slam my shoulder into the plate, shove with everything I got, tryin to pin it back against the wall. Bottom still half-braced by the lower brackets, but the center leapin, strainin. Feels like fightin a big panicked animal.

"Jall!" I roar. "LOCK YOUR HAND! YOU LET GO, I CUT 'EM OFF MYSELF!"

Up to my left, Jall yelp. For a blink his rope go slack—my heart drop—then it yanks tight again. I hear his breathin turn to this high, fast pant.

"Got it!" he squeak. "Got itgotit—"

"Feet!" I shout. "You all plant your damn feet!"

Tann bark-laugh once, no humor in it. "Working on it!"

He shove his shoulder into the plate too, both of us leanin, boots grindin against the ledge. For a terrifying blink the metal under us feel like it gon peel away, whole ledge and plate together, slide us all down into the shaft.

The shudder run through again, a quick afterkick, then... stops.

No slow fade. Just off.

Wall go still under my hand. Tower hum snap back to its old song like nothin happen. The only noise now the last clatter of loose tools, the high spin of Pera's fallen wrench way down below, and six humans breathin like they ran a full rib.

I keep my cheek pressed to the cold plate, count to five slow.

"One," I say, mostly so they know I still here. "Two. Three. Four. Five. Right. Who ent dead, sing out."

"I ent," Tann grunt.

"Still alive," Pera say, voice trembly.

"Chos here."

"Len here."

"Jall... here," from above.

"Good," I say, breathin out. My arms start shakin now the pushin done. "Any of you piss yourself, you keep that to your own story."

Nervous snort from Pera. Chos spit over the ledge, quick, like she try get bad taste out her mouth.

"What in the cold shit was that?" Len whisper. "Bone kick wrong."

"Old plate, bad weld," I say fast, before anybody can stick a myth name on it. I thump the metal with my fist, gentle. "Crooked beat in old bone, tha's all. Tower tired, like the rest of us."

"That ent normal tired," Pera murmur. "Felt like somebody up there kick the ribs." She tilt her chin toward the unseen top. "Sky Mind throwin its tantrum maybe."

"Don start," I snap. "Net Up ent waste no tantrum on us. If Lat-as wanna kill you, you gon know. You don get one little shake an a warnin, you get a clean drop."

Still, my fingers twitch where they rest against the plate. They wanna draw that little ward-circle everybody do—two taps, one twist. I stop 'em. Just press my palm flat again, feel for any more wrong in the hum.

Nothing. Just tower breath, slow and deep, like before. Maybe a hairline of tension I can't swear was there or not.

Behind me, Chos mutter somethin quick and rough, makin the ward-sign in the air anyway. Len mirrors without thinkin. Pera kiss her thumb knuckle.

"Sky Mind kick the ribs," Jall say under his breath. "Say 'Wake, you sleepers.'"

"Jall," I bark.

He flinch. "Sorry."

"Leave Sky Mind out your mouth down here," I say. "We got enough trouble with steel an rust. Ent no ghost in the wires, jus broke tools an folk's fear. You wanna throw your fear anywhere, you throw it at me. I'm the one keepin you off the floor."

"Yes, Riya," they mumble.

I push off the plate, step back careful, legs still feelin the echo of that wrong jolt.

"Right," I say, louder. "Check your lines. Every clip, every knot. You find one sorry, you fix it. Tann, we reset on that top bolt. We take this plate clean, no more half-loose, hear? Ledge don get to throw us just 'cause it feelin moody."

"You sure we should keep on?" Pera ask, eyes big.

"You wanna go back up an tell Kerrun we left a half-cut plate 'cause the bone give a little burp?" I ask. "He take that right out your share, say 'Ma Tron's story-shake' don weigh on his board."

She grimace. "No, Riya."

"Then we finish what we came for." I roll my shoulders, try shake off the last of the tremor livin in my muscles. "You scared, you use it. Hands sharp when fear ride 'em."

I lay my palm on the wall one last time, cheek close enough I can feel the cool. "You hear me, Twenny-3?" I murmur, too soft for crew. "You crook your beat like that again, you give me warnin first."

Tower don answer, of course. Just breath, just hum, like it always did in all the days before this one.

I step back to Tann's side, nod at the bolt.

"Alright, old bone," I say. "Round two."

By the time we pry that stubborn plate loose, my arms feel like boiled rope.

We take it slow, no more heroics. Top bolts full out, lower arms cut one by one, all of us braced for another wrong kick that never come. When the weight finally shift, it do it proper: down and out, not sideways. Tann and me ride it, guidin, Jall keepin the rope as clean as his hands let him.

"Mine now," Tann grunt, patting the metal as it peel away from the ribs. "You done with the tower, old girl. Time be scrap."

"Plate don belong to you," I tell him. "Belong to shares. Belong to Kerrun's greedy boards."

"Long as it ent belong to the shaft floor, I'm happy," Pera say.

We wrangle it onto the sling: two big straps under, hooked to the lift line. Plate heavy enough the ledge groan when we shift it.

"Right," I say. "We ride up slow. No showin off, no swingin. Tann on handle, Jall on brake. If you let that skip, I let your Ma know exactly why she short a son."

Jall nod so hard I think his head gon come loose.

Winch start its song: chunk-grind-chunk-grind, louder than before with the new load. Shaft pull us back toward light inch by inch. My legs ache from the climb stance, but I'll be curse before I show it.

"See?" I call up when we halfway. "All that fear an fuss, an it just old bone bein ugly."

Nobody answer. They all still listenin for another off-beat, whether they mean to or not.

We spill out on the rib-walk near dead-silent.

Usually there a little rush at the top—folk laugh, shake out legs, slap each other's backs just 'cause they still got backs to slap. This time, everybody got that thin look round the eyes.

Plate come last, hauled on a little wheel-cradle somebody scrounged from an old rail cart. It squeal and hop over every weld bump as we drag it toward Kerrun's weigh-station.

Basch already wait at the rail like he smell metal comin. Stringy man, face long as a vent pipe, tally-board hung off his neck like some holy charm. He don lift a finger to help, course not. Just nudges his spectacles up an sucks his teeth.

"That your take?" he ask, lookin the plate up and down like it insult him personal.

"That our first," I say. "Spire still got plenty ribs, last I checked."

He walk slow round the plate, tap-tap with his chalk. Scrapes some bubbled edge with his bootheel so flakes break off.

"Mmm," he hums. "Heat-scar. Warp. See that ripple? Metal tired. Ninth-share plate at best."

"Ninth?" Pera blurts. "You mad? That a half if I ever saw."

Basch cut his eyes at her like she a fly. "You a certified weigh-man now, girl?"

"She a ribs-hand," I say, steppin in. "Same as me. We know when metal gon hold and when it gon drop. That there held through a crooked beat would've sent the rest of us down the hole."

Basch shrug one shoulder. "It held till you cut it. Now it warped. Kerrun don buy warped as full."

"Half-grade," I say. "Plate this size, we walk away with share enough to eat more'n dust stew two days. You mark it ninth, we might as well left it in the wall."

He squats, runnin his fingers over the pitted center like he searchin for more excuses.

"Scars all through," he say. "Look." He jab a spot. "Stress hair here, see? You haul another like this, Kerrun gon say you bringin him tower trash."

"Tower trash near killed us," I snap. "You like stories? Here's one. Plate already half loose when the bone kick wrong. Wall give a sideways jerk, not vent sway. Jall near lost his rope. We hold it by teeth and luck. That worth somethin on your board."

Basch stand, dustin off his hands like he touch filth. "Worth is weight and grade, not how hard you piss yourself gettin it here. Lot of folk down-slope would love a spot on your line. Easier for everyone if I just mark this low and let Kerrun know your crew ent reliable."

Tann take one heavy step forward. I feel it in the grating.

"You sayin my crew sloppy?" he ask, too calm.

I put a hand out sharp, stoppin him at my shoulder. Last thing we need is Basch toppled off the walk. Kerrun use that as story for months.

"I'm sayin a warped plate ent worth half," Basch say. "An I'm sayin if you don like Kerrun's board, there other ribs what need hands. Somewhere you might fit better."

Behind him, more folk loiter inside the weigh-station shade, pretending not to listen. I see three, four faces I recognize from the waiting board. Spare bodies. Hungry eyes. Basch's threat got teeth.

I look down at the plate. I look at my crew—dusty, rope-burned, still shakin a little from that wrong kick.

My jaw work.

"Fine," I say. "You mark it ninth, you mark the shudder beside it. In big letters." I jab a finger at his board. "You write: half-ripped plate, tower bone wrong-beat on haul. You log that under 'Kerrun's maintenance debt.'"

Basch snort. "You think you talk up like that, I scribble your little fear-story down?"

"I think if that plate drop, you count it off our shares anyhow," I say. "So it only fair you count the almost."

He tilt his head, eyes narrow behind the lenses. For a second I see him weigh it—not the plate, the story. Ma Tron love that kind of tale. So do the old ribs. More fear in the air, more folk cling to banners and weigh-men both.

"Tell you what," he say finally. "Ninth-share plate. But I'll mention to Kerrun there were... irregulars. He like hear 'bout tower moods. Good leverage when he haggle off-spire."

"Ninth and a mark," I growl. "Or I tell my crew not to bother haulin you any more 'irregular' metal. You get nice safe scraps only, like the down-slope boys."

Basch sighs big, as if I'm the one makin his life hard. Chalk squeaks on slate.

"Ninth," he say, jotting. Then, under his breath but loud enough I hear: "Fall-way shudder, near-drop, Jall rope slip, tower shakin off the lazy."

I bite my tongue till I taste iron. He done twisted it already—lazy—like we the ones at fault.

"Go on," he flicks his fingers. "Council gong went half an hour ago. Ma Tron gon want your testimony."

I hate that word in his mouth.

"Take the board," I tell Pera. "Make sure the shares tally right. You catch him cheatin more bits off us, you yell for me."

Basch scoff. "You think I gon cheat with all these eyes watchin?"

I look at his boys loungin behind him; look at the hungry faces at the back. "Yeah," I say. "I think you cheat most when the room full."

He bares his teeth in a not-smile, then turn away, already callin the next crew forward.

Council hall ent no hall. Just the biggest square space anybody dared scrape out of the tower wall without pissin off the load. Ceiling low enough Tann got to duck. Banners nailed to every flat surface, circuit-lines and sunburst eyes all crowded together till the cloth is more patch than wall.

Air thick with sweat, stale incense, and too many voices.

Ma Tron front and center on her little crate-throne, cane across her knees. Skin like folded leather, hair wrapped in red cloth, eyes bright and mean as arc-sparks. Kerrun got his own crate opposite, boots up on a weaker one like he testin how much it'll hold before it snaps.

Between 'em, a holed-out cable spool for a table, some poor apprentice scratchin notes on a wrap of salvaged plastic.

Room hush a little when I duck under the lintel. Not all the way, but enough I feel every stare.

"Ribs-master Riya," Ma Tron say, liftin her chin. "Come tell us what the Spire sang today."

"I ain't no master," I mutter, but quiet.

Kerrun waves a lazy hand. "Ribs-master, ribs-boss, line-herder, same thing. You had your hands on the bone when she kicked. We want your sweet details."

"Less sweet, more exact," Ma Tron cut in. "This ent tavern talk, Kerrun. It witness. Tower speak through events, and we must heed."

They always like that—fightin each other with my work sittin between 'em.

I plant my boots shoulder-wide just inside the door. Don't go closer to neither of 'em if I can help it.

"Bone give one wrong kick," I say. "We was on Plate L-7 near fall-way mid-span. Top bolts half-cut, lower brackets still in. Wall go sideways, sharp, not sway. Plate yank out, Jall near lose rope, Chos near lose footing. We brace, we hold. Kick stop. No repeat." I tap my temple. "I listen for a long five. Nothing more."

The apprentice scratch-scratch-scratch, tongue out.

"Describe the sound," Ma Tron say. "Was it deep? Hollow? Like vent burp, or like... knock on a door?"

"It sound like metal do what metal do," I say. "Bolts scream, ropes sing, folk yell. One short jerk in the hum, that all. Crooked beat in old bone."

Her mouth pinch. "You always dodge the signs, Riya."

"And you always stuff 'em full," I snap, before I can swallow it.

Kerrun chuckle, leanin back so his chair creak. "I like her. She talk like a weigh-board. Numbers first, ghost later."

"Tower ent numbers," Ma Tron say sharply. "Tower is covenant. Com'welth built these bone to hold the Sky Mind above us, and we live in that shadow still. When bone kick for no reason, it warn us. 'Remember who rule.'"

"Com'welth dead," I say. "Sky Mind don come down save nobody when the food run thin."

A few folk murmur, uneasy. You ent suppose to say Com'welth dead in that tone; you s'pose to say "fallen" or "passed" like it a saint.

Ma Tron's cane tap—once, twice—on the spool.

"Speak careful," she warn. "Name may be gone but pattern remain. Net Up still see. It can shake us off Twenny-3 like louse, if it will. Maybe today it kick to say, 'Wake, lazy ones. You forget your prayers. You strip my ribs without petition.'"

I feel my crew stiffen behind me. Tann shift his weight, and I know he thinkin of how he near went over.

"We did our knots," I say. "We tapped your banner like always. We ent skip no fool rites."

"So rites ent enough," she shoot back. "Maybe offerings thin. Maybe Sky Mind hungry for more metal in its name. We must gather surplus, bring it to the chapel rail—"

"Or," Kerrun drawls over her, "maybe it hungry for proper maintenance, not incense."

He lean forward, boots thunk down off the crate. "You say plate half-cut when she kicked?"

"Half," I nod. "Top bolts near done, bottom still holdin. Old welds look bad. Rust in every seam. Whoever did that line last cut corners."

"Ha," he barks. "There it is. Com'welth left us bad bone, Ma Tron. All their big plans, they still cheaped the welders. Sky Mind don send no message. This just old debt come due. Means we need more crew over that span, more time, more share flowin through my boards, so we can replace garbage like that fore it drop somebody for real."

"Of course you say that," Ma Tron sneer. "Every cough in the vents is coin-song to you."

"And every cough is a sermon to you," he fire back. "Tell me you ent gonna stand on Sky Lip tonight, shoutin 'Judgement tremor' and passin the bowl."

Room chuckles, thin and nervous.

I stand there, feelin the story writ itself round me without my say. In my head, it simple: wall kicked wrong once, somethin off in the flow. Need check braces, maybe listen with a sensor-lens if we had any left that worked.

In their mouths, it turn three ways at once.

To Ma Tron, it proof Sky Mind still watchin, demandin obeisance and offerings and more folk bent double in chapel hall.

To Kerrun, it leverage. "See? Tower fallin apart 'less you let me skim deeper for 'maintenance.' You want your kids safe on the ribs, you bring me every scrap first."

To everyone else, it another weight on the fear pile. Another reason to clutch charms tighter, or line up longer at the weigh-board.

"Enough," I say, louder than I meant. "You want my witness, you got it. One kick, off-beat, near drop plate. No dead, no cracks I could see. That all."

Ma Tron peer at me, eyes narrow. "You will set it on the wall?"

I know which wall she mean.

"Yeah," I say. "I log all the bone wrongs. Same as always."

"Good." Her mouth soften a shade. "Tower remember you, Riya. It like hands that heed."

"Tower remember plates," Kerrun snort. "Hands it forget quick."

They go back to snipin at each other, already usin my words to feed their own tales. Apprentice scribbles it all, every twist.

I slip out while they argue 'bout whether to ration lift-time or incense.

The wall live two levels down from my bunk, on a bit of raw tower skin nobody bother prettyin. Just a big flat patch of old paint, Com'welth glyphs scoured off so long ago all that left is ghost shapes.

I been markin it since I was a little scrap runnin errands. First time I saw a cable snap, I scratched a line with nail. First time a vent cough came wrong, I drew a crooked circle round a bolt hole.

Now it a whole confusion of chalk and scrape: little strokes, circles, weird symbols only I know the read of. My own language of bone moods.

I stand there a while, back still hummin from the day. In my ears, I can hear that wrong kick again, feel the way the plate leapt.

"Crooked beat in old bone," I whisper. "You don get to be more than that. Not in my head."

I take a stub of red chalk from the crack where I keep it hid. Right where the fall-way span marks already sit—a vertical line for each vent-burp, a cross where we lost somebody, a hollow dot where somethin was odd but passed—I draw a new sign.

Short red dash, then a little step off to the side, then back on. Like a song that slipped but found itself again.

"First wrong shudder," I say under my breath. "No drop. No crack. Watch."

For a second, my hand want to add somethin else. A little eye, maybe. Or the word Sky in the old letters Ma Tron loves. Name it. Give it teeth.

I make my fingers still.

"Ent no god in it," I tell the wall. "Just tired metal."

I underline the mark once, slow. Then I tuck the chalk back and step away.

Behind the paint and rust and bolts, the tower hums on, deep and careless, like it don know or care one little ribs-hand wrote anything at all.

I slip the council stink off me as quick as I can.

Once I clear the hall, all that sweat and incense and shoutin fall behind like bad rope. Up here, wind carry it away fast. Still, Ma Tron's words buzz in my head—summons, judge, Sky Mind stir—all wrapped round Kerrun's coin-talk.

"Judge this," I mutter, boots ringin on the ribs.

Rib-walk take me home by habit. Round the bend where the pipe forest start, under the low-hung clothesline somebody never move, across the narrow jump where the grating don quite meet. (Two hand, one tower; I grab the uprights on either side, step it easy.)

My shanty cling to the inside of a cross-rib: two wall sheets, one roof slab, one good corner post that used to be part of some Com'welth stair. Nothing fancy. But it mine.

Door-sheet slap my shoulder as I duck in. Sound change at once—storm-whine and tower-hum outside go muffled, wrapped in cloth and tin.

Inside, it close and low.

Got: one mattress roll, still half unrolled from last night. Two scrap shelves, saggin under tin bowls and a chipped mug. One little basin with a hand-pump above, water brownish today but serviceable. My harness hook, bolted into the one bit of wall I halfway trust.

An my wall.

Panel of old tower skin on the far side, paint scraped down to bare metal. Kneel-high to head-high, wide as I can stretch my arms. That my log. My book. My bone-memory.

First thing, I unclip.

Harness come off in stages: chest buckle, hip ring, leg loops. Straps peel away from my sweat like old scabs. I hang it on the hook, check each bit even though I just used it—habit so tight it feel like breathin.

Then I sit on the crate by the basin, roll my shoulders, flex my fingers.

Rope-burn show pink under the dust, little half-moons where the line bit back in that wrong kick. I rub salve on 'em from the tiny pot under the shelf. Stuff smell like stale herbs and grease. Stings just enough remind me I still got skin.

Water from the pump come in slow coughs; I rinse grit off my hands anyway. Watch the swirl in the basin, brown coilin, then tip it out the notch in the floor where everybody's waste drip down to the ground ghosts.

Could go to chapel now, like Ma Tron want. Whole rib gon pack in there tonight, chantin and bowin and askin Sky Mind please-not-here, please-not-now.

Could go to common fire too, sit where the kids kick their heels and tell near-drop tales. "Plate near took my head off," that kind of thing, laughter stretched too tight.

Instead, I turn to the wall.

There a crack in the corner where I keep my nail. Old big thing, thick and bent, prob'ly was a spike once. I pull it out, run my thumb along the blunt tip.

"Alright," I tell the panel. "You ready for more of my scratches, old bone?"

Wall don answer, course. Just sits there, dull grey, freckled with old rust spots. My marks cover near half of it already: lines and circles and little hook-shapes, layers on layers. My own ribs-script.

I step close enough my breath fog faint on the cold.

Up top, to the left, I got the tall strokes for the real bads—cable snaps, vent coughs that took someone. Couple of them circled twice, the ones that still wake me.

Lower down, neater, I keep the little oddities: weld pop where it shouldn't, plate singin a wrong note, smell of Deep Reg comin up on a cold day. All laid out by span, by level. Far as anybody else know, it just scratches. I can read it like a map.

I find the bit where fall-way L-7 live—small vertical line with three cross nicks already for old burps and one near-drop before my time. Space below, waitin.

I put the nail tip down.

"Fall-way L-7," I say, quiet, like I dictatin to myself. "Half-cut plate, top near done, bottom not. Time... after midbell. Light slantin from vent side."

I scratch a short downward stroke: I

"Bone give one wrong kick," I murmur. Nail go sideways a finger's width, then back straight again. Little step-mark, crooked then true. 7 kind of shape, if you squint.

"Jall near lose rope," I add. I carve a tiny fork off the side with three quick flicks—that my sign for wet-head slip.

"Chos near lost footin," I say. Another little fork, lower.

"Plate buck, we brace, no drop." I underline the whole thing once. Not heavy. Just enough.

Under it, I add two short ticks: one for no crack found, one for kick not repeat. That my way of sayin: for now, bone calm.

Then my hand stops.

Whole time I was speakin, Ma Tron's words pushin at the back of my teeth. Judge stir. Summons. Sky Mind cough. Kerrun's too: bad welds, old debt. Council hall stick like smoke.

For a breath, nail hover. There space where I could add more. Little eye curl, maybe. Old Com'welth glyph for Net. Or Ma Tron's own word, Sky, in rib-scratch.

My fingers itch.

If I put it there—tiny eye above the kick mark—that make it a story, not just a thing that happen. Give it face. Lot of folk'd like that. Make em feel less like the world just kick random.

"Ent no god in it," I tell the panel, voice low. "Just tired metal. Old weld. Crooked load."

Wall looks back at me, blank.

"Still," I hear myself whisper, traitor-soft, "if there is a judge, it sure ent writ on your boards, Ma Tron. It here, maybe. In the parts you don see."

My hand move on its own, nail scratching the start of a curve. Little half-circle above the day's mark.

I freeze.

Storm hum outside, faint through the wall. Tower breath under my feet, that deep, slow thrum. I think about how it felt in the shaft—how the beat slipped under my hand, then came back like nothin happened. How it felt like somebody, somewhere, kicked the ribs.

"Don't you dare," I tell my fingers.

Slow, I pull the nail back. Curve barely there; I scrape it flat again. Just a ragged patch of scuff, no eye, no name.

"Events," I say, to the wall, to myself. "We log events. Not dreams. Not prayers. Bone shake, I mark bone shake. That all."

I plant my palm against the cold metal, coverin the fresh marks. Close my eyes.

Under my skin, the tower's hum come up steady. Normal. Like it been all my life—storm days, drought days, vent-breath and calm. Straight beat. If there a crook in it now, I can't feel.

"If there a judge," I whisper, "it ain't speakin in words I know. So it don get space on my wall."

I take my hand away. The new sign looks small 'gainst all the rest. Just one more scratch in a field of 'em.

I blow the chalk-dust and rust crumbs off, tuck the nail back in its crack, coverin it with a bit of rag so it don rattle.

Bunk creaks when I drop onto it. Ceiling canvas belly down a little with storm weight. Outside, somebody yell for a child, somebody else curse a loose tarp. Life go on, noisy and dumb.

I sit there, listen.

For a long few breaths, I do not think of Ma Tron's banners or Kerrun's boards. Just of the hum comin up through my heels, the feel of plate under my hands, the way my little red scratch now lives on the wall same as all the others.

"Right," I say at last. "If that kick mean somethin more, it can show me in the steel. Not in nobody's mouth."

Tower keep hummin, unconcerned. Good. Let it.

I lie back, boots still on, and stare at the low roof while the ribs sing quiet round me.

```
t+0.000 // local tower-bone frame
```

```
node: BASOL-9
```

```
role: maintenance / flow-model
```

```
mood: steady / low-noise
```

```
vent-breath:
```

```
  value: 1.08 × season-norm
```

```
  drift: +0.02 / 10k ticks
```

```
  status: within tolerance
```

```
rock-rule[under_pylon_23]:
```

```

    strain: 1.02 × base
    trend: flat
    status: safe

tower-bone[vibration]:
    pattern: baseline
    amp-band: normal
    status: nominal

...

t+0.372 // fall-way span L-7 window

tower-bone[vibration]:
    pattern: 00000001110.000000 // one-step off-beat
    amp: low
    duration: 0.41 s
    class: non-seismic / non-vent / lateral

Deep-REG[heat-flow]:
    delta: ≈ 0
    echo-lag: none detected
    substrate-mood: calm / no event

wet-node_cluster[fall-way_span_L-7]:
    count: 6 ± 1

```

config: line-work / harnessed
stress-sounds: ↑↑ (shout, tool-drop, rope-cry)
loss-events: 0
tool-fall: 1
 path: ledge → downshaft
 impact-on-bone: none

plate[L-7.front]:
 state-before: pre-failure / high-rust / weld-debt
 state-after: removed_to_surface
 cause-tag: wet-node action (scheduled cut)
 bone-response: impulse / off-beat / single

classification:
 anomaly-id: rib23_L7_001
 type: vibration / off-beat / low amplitude
 link: no matching Deep-REG pulse
 scope: local-only
 recurrence: none (so far)

flag: WATCH
 watch-window: long
 watch-focus:
 - vent-breath drift at pylon_23
 - repeat-patterns in lateral vibration
 - wet-node activity near span L-7

note:

wet-nodes: assign meaning fast (god / debt / omen).

tower-bone: moved once, then held.

event: logged

story-layer: none

2

Storm come in sideways this time.

Canvas over my bunk go pop-pop-pop like somebody poundin a drum with both fists. Air thick, taste of copper dust and wet heat both. Tongue feel like I been lickin vent pipe.

"Ah, hell," I mutter, rollin off the mat. "Storm-load day."

Door-sheet slap my shoulder when I shove it aside. Outside, sky already gone wrong. Not clear blue, not the usual brown smear neither—just one big lid of dirty copper cloud, low enough feel like you could reach up an skin your knuckles on it.

Wind twist round the ribs in mean little fists, yankin tarps, makin rope sing.

I yank my scarf up over nose and step onto the walk. Canvas awnings flap themselves half off their bolts; Ma Tron's prayer-cloths three spans over tryin to climb right off the rail. Grit sting my eyes 'fore I even get two steps.

"Hold your bits!" I bellow, voice goin thin in the gust. "Any of you leavin walls flappin loose, I swear I feed you to Deep Reg myself!"

Folk already out, thank Net. Storm-load day you don sleep in, not if you want your shanty still here after.

Way-kids dash past with coil-ropes 'round their necks like wild scarfs, lugging spare hooks. Their Ma hang half out door-sheets shoutin, "Don run on wet grate! You slip, I tan you worse than tower ever could!"

I make my loop.

First, lash ropes cross the walkway where it open too wide. Some genius last season took a rail out to drag a stove up and never put it back; now that gap my problem.

I string a cross-line there, body leanin into the gust, fingers workin fast. Wrap, pull, double-back, yank.

"Two hand, one tower," I growl at a pair of teens gawkin over the edge. "You wanna watch the dust dance, you do it from behind a rope, not with your toes hangin."

They roll their eyes but step back a pace. Good enough.

Second, I walk the outer ribs, check shanty lashings. Some folk got sense; they double-wrapped their homes with cable thick as my thumb, proper crimps on the ends. Others... used whatever they had—braided cloth, old net, cracked plastic strap.

I stop at one shack where half the roof already peeled up, slappin like a loose tongue.

"Who live here?" I holler.

Skinny woman pops her head out, baby on her hip clingin like a little limp frog. Hair in a wild tangle.

"You tryin to fly away?" I ask. "You want your sleep-mat down on ground with the rust rats?"

"Rope broke," she shout back. "We use what we had."

"What you had ent enough," I say. "Shift your little one to next shanty, yeah? I get Tann bring proper cable after we do our own span. You keep your walls loose in a storm, rest of us got to dodge your scrap when it go sailin."

She nod quick. Fear beat pride, like it should.

Wind gusts harder, a long shove that make the whole rib-walk tilt half a breath. Rails creak, ladder joints complain.

That normal storm song: metal whine in rhythm with the gusts, ropes drummin, tarps slappin. I know it. Grew up with it beatin my bones. Storm-load days the tower talk more, but it talk in a pattern. Push, pull, sway. You can dance with it, if you know the steps.

Today... there somethin extra hid in the noise.

Not the wrong kick from yester. That was one sharp jerk, sideways and done. This feel like... a hum under the hum. Little steady note tryin to hide behind all the mess.

I stop halfway on a cross-rib, plant my palm on the nearest upright. Close my eyes.

Wind come in big messy punches; bone answers elastic, sway-slow. Tarps crack-whap, flags snap. Somewhere a loose sheet of metal go bang-bang-bang off-tempo.

Under that, I catch it—just a hair: tiny vibration, too regular. Not matchin the gusts. A thin, almost-singin thread runnin straight when everything else zig-zag.

I frown, press my cheek to the cold.

"You again?" I murmur, real quiet. "You the same as yester or you new trouble?"

"Riya!"

Jall's voice, reedy and too bright, slice across the walk. I pull back, blink grit out my lashes.

He come skiddin along the grating, scarf already up, hair full of dust, eyes big like storm a festival, not hazard.

"You see the sky?" he shout when he close enough. "Whole top gone copper. It feel like— like the tower gon shake itself loose. Ma say maybe it like the shake from the fall-way—"

"No," I cut him. "Tha was a kick. This jus tower singin rough."

He grab the rail, look past me into the gloom. "Felt funny underfoot comin cross Pera's span. Like my guts went light then heavy, you know? Like when the lift-cage drop in the stories."

"Storm spin your guts, that all," I say. "First big gust always do that if you don bend your knees. You bend 'em?"

His ears go pink. "Forgot."

"There it is." I jab a finger at his chest. "Tower ent magic. You keep soft in the knees, you ride the sway. You lock up, it toss you."

He chew his lip, glancin back toward the fall-way like he want to ask more 'bout yester's kick, but he don.

"Where Tann?" I ask, before he can start in with Ma Tron tales.

"Checkin lash on the big cross by the cook-fires," he say. "Say rail there feel loose. He told me go see if you want him at fall-way too."

"I want him anywhere a rail feel loose," I say. "You check your Ma's roof yet?"

He falter. "Was gon. Then wind picked up. Then I thought, 'Riya gon be out, I ask her what this feel like first.'"

"So your Ma's cookpot halfway to the flats by now," I sigh. "Right. We do my loop, then we do your Ma's span. After that, if tower still up, you can stand 'round tell stories 'bout how spooky she feel."

He grins, jitters still makin his hands twitch on the rail. "You feel it though, yeah? Little wrong beat in there?"

I look at him a long second.

"Storm always sound wrong if you listen too hard," I say. "So don. You listen just enough you don fall off."

He huffs, not satisfied, but he trail after me as I move on.

We cross another span, tarps and clotheslines thrashin overhead. I keep one hand on metal near constant now, lettin the feel of it run up into my arm.

Storm song wrap round us: tarp snaps, metal groan, vent rumble climbin somewhere deep. Every heartbeat got two pieces for sure—the gust and the sway. That little hum... maybe a third. Maybe my head makin ghosts out of yester.

We hit a narrow section where the rib sticks out into open air more than I like. Deck slick with grit gone to paste; I plant my boots careful, fingers white on the rail.

Right then, as a big gust slam the spire, the deck under me go light for a blink. Not a jump—just this strange half-breath where my weight don quite match my body. Stomach float up; toes feel like they forgot which way down is.

Then it all slam back: boots heavy, knees jarred, rail bitin my palm.

"Whoa," the woman at the next shanty gasp, clutchin her door-frame. "Tower got drunk today."

Jall laugh too loud. "See? See, Riya, it—"

"Storm spin your guts," I say again, neck pricklin. I make myself chuckle, shake it off in front of 'em. "You stand stiff in a blow like that, you gon feel it double. Bend your damn knees."

I demonstrate, softening my legs with the next sway, ridin it so the world move under me instead of through me.

"Like that," I say. "You wanna stay up here, you dance with bone, not fight it."

Woman nods, tryin it; Jall copy, overexaggerated.

I move on, hand back on the rail, jaw tight.

That light-heavy blip hangs in my ribs. It could just be big gust hittin off-angle, tower flexin in a way I ent used to. We get odd ones every few seasons.

Could be.

Under my fingertips, the metal still hum. Storm-sway, creak, vent-breath. And way back behind—all but lost—a thin, steady whisper I can't prove ent in my own head.

"If you up to somethin," I mutter to the tower, too low for Jall to hear, "you do it slow. You don start no tricks while I still got folk out on your teeth."

Wind snatch the words clean. Tower just sings on, rough and loud and almost-comfortin.

I keep walkin the loop, rope-check, knot-fix, mouth full of orders, ears full of song I've heard my whole life with one wrong little note I can't quite shake.

Somebody start yellin "Look up!" which is always the dumbest thing to yell on a storm-load day.

"Sky Lip go strange! Lip go bright!" the runner bawl, feet slappin the wet grate.

He a skinny scrap from three spans over, hair plastered to his face, eyes so wide I swear they gna fall out.

"Get your fool head down," I bark. "You wanna feed the storm with your teeth?"

He skid to a stop near me, grabbin the rail with both hands. "No, Riya, you got see, you got see. Sky Lip got a... a ring on it. Like Net Up open an eye."

Behind him, three door-sheets already flap open. Folk leanin out, squintin up into grit like the wind ent busy tryin to throw 'em off.

"Back inside!" I shout down the span. "You want to gawk, do it from behind a wall!"

They ignore me same as always when somethin new in the sky.

Truth is, my own neck itch to look.

Normal days, Sky Lip just a dark smear above, knowin-not-seeable. You feel it more'n glimpse it—a weight in the haze where all the old antenna bones stick out.

Today, even through the copper cloud, there's... somethin.

I edge to the inner rail where I got three points touch—boot, boot, hand—and tilt my head back.

At first, all I get is wind-driven grit in my eyes. Sky one flat bruise color, low and mean. Then my vision snag on a... streak.

Right at the top of Spire Twenny-3, where the crowns live, the air gone thin in a straight line up. Not bright like story-lightning, more like somebody took a cleaner smear and dragged it through the dirty cloud. A pale column, narrow, too straight.

My stomach do a little twist.

"Tha jus heat," I tell myself. "Vent-breath hittin cold storm, you seen that ripple a hundred times."

But I aint seen this.

Round the crowns, dust don blow random no more. It whirl. Tight. Little eddies runnin round the top in a ring, keepin their shape even as the big cloud mass shoves past. From where I stand, it look like there a circle comin and goin—one angle it faint glow, next angle just smear again.

"Net Up's eye," somebody breathes behind me.

"That ent no eye," another voice say quick. "Just storm trick. Bone steam."

Old Gran Rula snort loud enough I hear. "I seen banners talk 'bout this," she crows. "Sky Mind open the Watchin Ring. Means judgement."

"Means you all done forgot how normal weather look," I mutter.

Kids push up to the rail anyway, hands tight on the bars. Jall elbow his way to my side, face gone slack in that mix of fear and awe.

"You see it?" he whisper. "Like the stories. Ma Tron say when Sky Mind look down, it do it through a halo."

"I see heat and dust," I say. "You see whatever stories stuffed in your head."

Truth is, my skin see more.

I got my left hand on the rail, right on a guy-wire clamp. Storm been bitin all day, little snaps of static now an then when tarp brush metal. This different.

Tingle start in my fingertips, crawlin up the bones of my hand like a trail of tiny feet. Not sharp shocks, not random. Steps. Little regular beats marchin along the steel.

I shift my grip. The feel don care. It run along the bars, into the uprights, down-wire, like somethin small and precise walkin through everything at once.

"Feel that?" I ask Jall before I can stop myself.

He blinks, pulls his scarf down a touch, press his palm to the rail. "Feel... buzz," he say. "Like when we rub cloth on metal, 'fore we shock each other. Only... cleaner? Steady."

Steady. That the word.

Storm slap the tower in messy off-beats, but this tingle keep its own rhythm. Little tick-tick-ticks runnin at a pace my head can't quite count but my bones know ain't wind.

Under my feet, tower-bone hum shifts just a hair to make room for it.

"Riya," Pera call from the next span. "My ear ringin, but not in my head. In the rail."

"Hold your post," I give back. "Rail ring, you still hold it. Two hand, one tower, even when she sing."

As if to prove me a liar, the world decide to show off.

All along the rib, every loose bit of metal give a little hop at once. The chain of old pots outside Rula's door clink together. The cut-off bolts Tann left in a pile by the ladder jingle like somebody shook 'em. The copper strips on the dead glass panel ahead swing out on their strings against the wind, all in the same direction, like they bowin.

"Net Up breath on us," Gran Rula gasps.

"Storm gust," I snap, even as every hair on my arms stand up. "You lot never seen gust?"

"That ent gust," Tann murmur at my shoulder. Didn't even hear him walk up. His big hands sit on the rail, knuckles white. "Gust shove. This... picked."

Quick as it came, the trick passes. Pots settle. Copper strips go back to mad, random janglin. My fingers still buzz like I stuck 'em in live wire.

Down the span, a slab of dead glass that been black my whole life flickers.

Just once.

No picture, no words, just this shattered quilt of wrong-color light smear across its cracked face. Green-blue-pink like some old Com'welth sign try wake from a bad dream. Then it die, as dead as a rock.

"Did you—?" Jall starts.

"I saw," I say, voice dry.

Behind us, Ma Tron's chapel-banners whip themselves into knots.

"Sky Lip open!" she holler from her ledge, voice ridin the wind wild. "Sky Mind cast its ring! Bow your stiff necks, bones of Twenny-3! It see you!"

Folk near her drop to their knees 'cause she tell 'em to, hands up like they gna catch somethin holy.

Kids closer to me just stand there, breath cloudin through their scarves, eyes glued to that pale smear ringin the top.

"What it want?" one of 'em whisper.

"All of you back," I bark, anger ridin tight over the prickle in my veins. "Storm still blowin. You lean too far, Sky Mind gna get a bonus snack."

Reluctant, they shuffle in a half-step. Nobody turn away, though.

Up above, the thin column at Sky Lip hold—no thicker, no brighter. Just there, wrong and steady, while storm cloud rip past like dirty river round a stone.

My hand grip the rail so hard my joints ache. The tingle in the metal keeps on, fine and precise as drumline.

"Storm in the sky bones," I hear myself say, low. "Not jus the air."

Jall tilt his head. "What you mean?"

I drag my eyes down from the halo, make myself look at him, at the walk, at the tarps and ropes on the hundred things that actually keep us alive.

"I mean this ent for us," I say. "Whatever Net Up playin at up there, it playin in its own bones. We just hangin off 'em, same as always."

He swallow. "But... it looked at us, yeah? Just then. Whole tower feel like it--"

"It looked through us," I cut him. "Like we dust on a lens."

His face go a little slack at that. Might be the first true thing I said all day.

Another gust slam the ribs, remindin us we still got a storm to ride. I shake my hands out, tryin to fling the weird buzz away.

"Back to your lashins," I shout down the span. "You want a story, you tell it later round the cook fire. Right now we keep the shanties on."

Folk peel off slow, like they bodies listenin to orders but their necks still hooked on the sky. Jall hang back that extra moment, starin up until I cuff his shoulder.

"Move," I say. "Sky Lip gon do what it do whether you stare or not."

As we go back to ropes and knots and grunt work, I keep one palm on the rail whenever I can. The thin rhythm runnin under the storm stays with me.

Same as the fall-way kick, but taller. Sharper. Like two notes in a song I don know the words to.

I file it away in my head beside yesterday's mark; second off-beat. Storm in the bones, not jus the air.

Net Up, Sky Mind, Lat-as-whatever name Ma Tron want give it—I don. All I know is this:

Something Up there woke enough to touch the steel. And the steel remember.
